The Boilerplate Decade: How Much of the Rise in Artificial-Intelligence Language in Annual Reports Is Substantive, 2015 to 2026

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Abstract

The share of Form 10-K annual reports that contain the phrase "artificial intelligence" rose from 0.50 percent in 2015 to 49.2 percent in 2025 and to 60.5 percent of the filings made in 2026 through 18 October, a 99-fold increase in a decade. That count is used, by researchers, by index providers and by the financial press, as a measure of how far AI has spread through public companies. This paper measures what the count is counting. Under a preregistration committed before any sample was drawn, 315 filings were sampled across the twelve calendar years from 2015 to 2026, every AI sentence in them was extracted by a fixed splitter, and the 2,242 sentences that survived a term audit were each classified by two independent blinded language-model passes against a rubric reused unchanged from a companion study of 2025 filings, with a third pass on every disagreement, thirty known-answer controls, and a blinded calibration review.

The composition of AI language inverted. Weighting filings equally within each year and years by their place in the frame, the share of a filing's AI sentences that are risk-factor language rose from 12.0 percent in 2015 to 2019 to 63.0 percent in 2024 to 2026, a change of 51.1 percentage points with a bootstrap interval from 40.5 to 60.8, while the share that claims a capability of the registrant's own AI fell from 40.6 to 15.7 percent and the share that states any use of AI by the registrant fell from 51.5 to 31.2 percent. The shift survives a blinded calibration review. At the filing level the picture is different: the fraction of AI-mentioning filers that state their own use of AI somewhere in the document has stayed near three in five throughout, 61.6, 71.9 and 61.5 percent across the three eras, so a mention still usually comes with an own-use statement, but it now arrives inside a much larger body of defensive text. Scaling each year's raw count by that year's sampled fraction puts the share of all 10-K filers stating their own use of AI at 25.6 percent in 2025 (interval 15.7 to 35.4), the year with the lowest sampled fraction, and at 41.2 percent (29.1 to 50.8) in 2026, against raw shares of 49.2 and 60.5.

A computational boilerplate detector, the number of other registrants whose 10-Ks contain the same twelve-word phrase, measured against the whole EDGAR corpus for every sentence, finds that verbatim cross-filer reuse is rare but almost entirely confined to risk language: 18.4 percent of risk sentences are shared with five or more other registrants against none of 864 capability sentences, and the flagged share of a filing's AI sentences rose from zero in 2015 to 2019 to 12.3 percent in 2024 to 2026. Of seven preregistered predictions, four held with intervals clear of zero, one held on one of its two criteria with the other undecidable, one was not supported, and one failed at its stated boundary. All sentences, judgements, prompts and code are published.

1. Introduction

Counting how many annual reports mention artificial intelligence is the cheapest measure of corporate AI adoption there is. The phrase is unambiguous, the filings are public, and EDGAR's full-text search returns the count in under a second. The count has also risen in a way that invites a story: fewer than one filing in two hundred mentioned the phrase in 2015, nearly one in two did in 2025, and three in five have so far in 2026. Whoever reads that series as a diffusion curve is treating a mention as an adoption.

This paper asks whether that reading is honest, and how its honesty has changed over time. There are two ways it could fail. A filing can mention AI only to say that AI is a risk, that competitors have it, that regulators are interested in it, or that the board has a policy about it, and none of those is an adoption. And even a filing that does state its own use of AI can surround that statement with so much defensive language that the count of AI sentences in filings says more about the drafting conventions of securities counsel than about the technology. The first failure is about what fraction of filers are counted wrongly. The second is about what fraction of the language is counted wrongly. They have different consequences for different users of the measure, and the paper measures both.

The design is a direct extension of a companion study I ran in September 2026 on 60 annual reports filed in 2025 (Shah 2026b), the second in a series of preregistered audits of published measures that began with an annotation audit of a fruit-detection benchmark (Shah 2026a). That study found that a calibrated 60.5 percent of AI sentences were risk-factor language and 12.2 percent were claims about the registrant's own AI, and it closed with three things it could not do: say anything about trend, publish the literal prompts given to its rating passes, or detect boilerplate without a model reading every sentence. This study adds eleven years, a committed prompt, a computational detector, and one additional judgement, whether the sentence states that the registrant itself uses AI, that the adoption literature needs and the companion's rubric did not record. The rubric, the splitter and the extraction rules are otherwise reused without change, so the 2025 result can be compared directly.

The answer, in one paragraph, is that both failures are real, that one has moved and the other has not. The language has diluted: an AI-mentioning filing in 2015 to 2019 spent two fifths of its AI sentences describing what its own AI did and one in eight describing risk, and a filing in 2024 to 2026 spends one sixth on capability and nearly two thirds on risk. The filers have not changed in the same way: about three in five AI-mentioning filers state their own use of AI somewhere in the document in every era, with no detectable trend. So a sentence count of AI language has become a poor proxy for adoption, a filing count remains a usable proxy once scaled by a factor that has stayed between 1.4 and 1.6 by era, and the paper reports that factor with its uncertainty for every year.

2. Related work

The textual-analysis literature in accounting and finance has long warned that a word count built for one purpose will be wrong in systematic ways when used for another. Loughran and McDonald (2011) showed that general-purpose sentiment dictionaries misclassify financial language and built finance-specific lists, and their 2016 survey argues that textual measures are far less precise than the quantitative measures they are placed beside and catalogues the implementation tripwires. Dyer, Lang and Stice-Lawrence (2017) documented that 10-K length, boilerplate, stickiness and redundancy all rose between 1996 and 2013 and that a handful of topics, risk factors prominent among them, account for most of the growth. Lang and Stice-Lawrence (2015) built the standard

boilerplate measure from four-word phrases that recur across a country's filings. Cazier and Pfeiffer (2016) partitioned 10-K length into complexity, redundancy and discretion. Brown and Tucker (2011) showed that year-over-year modification of the MD&A declined even as the section grew. Hoberg and Phillips (2016) are the canonical example of a measure built from 10-K text that was validated against something outside the text. This paper sits in that tradition: it takes a text-based measure that is already in wide informal use and asks what it is measuring.

On risk-factor disclosure specifically, Campbell et al. (2014) found that mandated risk factors carry firm-specific information, and Hope, Hu and Lu (2016) found that specific risk-factor language is rewarded while generic language, which practitioners had long called boilerplate, is not. Redigolo and Marcarini (2026) is the closest precedent for the trend question: for Item 1A risk factors from 2019 to 2024 they detect a jump in AI-generated text after ChatGPT and find it more standardised and less specific. Their object is who wrote the risk factors, and mine is what share of the AI language the risk factors have become.

On AI adoption measurement, Babina, Fedyk, He and Hodson (2024) measure AI investment from employee resumes, Eisfeldt, Schubert and Zhang (2023) from occupational exposure, Li (2025) contrasts AI talk on earnings calls with AI walk in hiring and finds that talk does not predict walk, Barrios, Campbell, Johnson and Liu (2025) find that AI disclosures drawn from 10-Ks, earnings statements and calls do predict later efficiency and patents, Liu (2024) builds a firm-level exposure measure from managerial discussion, Akbari (2026) dates each firm's shift from AI talk to deployment from call transcripts, and Juma'h (2026) finds vague and promotional AI language in the 10-Ks of AI-driven firms. Zhang and Rivera (2026) and Ofir (2026) treat AI washing as a governance and legal problem respectively. Outside filings, Bonney et al. (2024) and McElheran et al. (2024) measure AI use from Census Bureau surveys, and the Business Trends and Outlook Survey now publishes a fortnightly AI-use rate. The literature verifier for this paper could not find a peer-reviewed paper whose abstract describes counting "artificial intelligence" mentions in 10-Ks as its adoption measure, which is itself worth stating: the count is used far more often in practice than it is defended in print.

On language models as annotators, Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli (2023) found that zero-shot ChatGPT beat crowd workers on text-annotation accuracy and agreement, de Kok (2025) gives a framework for generative models in accounting text work, Hansen and Kazinnik (2023) and Jha et al. (2024) validate model-coded measures against human and survey benchmarks. This study follows the companion's position that model passes must be checked against known answers and a blinded review rather than trusted.

3. Data

3.1 The frame and the denominator

For each calendar year from 2015 to 2026, the frame is every original Form 10-K (not an amendment) whose main document matches the exact phrase "artificial intelligence" in EDGAR full-text search, with the 2026 frame running through 18 October, the day the preregistration was written. EDGAR returns one hit per document, so hits were collapsed to filings by accession number and restricted to filings in which the 10-K document itself matched rather than only an exhibit. The restriction matters at the margin: in 2025 it turns 3,324 raw hits, the figure the companion study enumerated, into 3,162 original filings from 3,153 registrants. Both counts are published. The denominator is the number of filings of form type exactly 10-K in the EDGAR full index for the same year. Across the twelve years the frame holds 13,586 filings out of 82,684 10-Ks.

Table 1 gives the series. The raw share rises in every year, from 0.50 percent in 2015 to 16.9 percent in 2023, then jumps to 35.0 percent in 2024, 49.2 percent in 2025 and 60.5 percent in 2026 to date. The 2024 jump is the year in which filings for fiscal 2023, the first full fiscal year after the release of ChatGPT, were made.

year	frame	all 10-Ks	raw share
2015	38	7,659	0.50%
2016	45	7,259	0.62%
2017	110	6,984	1.58%
2018	271	6,827	3.97%
2019	400	6,660	6.01%
2020	511	6,508	7.85%
2021	734	6,933	10.59%
2022	1,071	7,538	14.21%
2023	1,206	7,118	16.94%
2024	2,324	6,631	35.05%
2025	3,162	6,431	49.17%
2026 to 18 Oct	3,714	6,136	60.53%

Table 1. Original 10-K filings whose main document contains "artificial intelligence", all original 10-K filings, and the raw mention share, by calendar year of filing.

3.2 The sample

Within each year the frame was collapsed to one filing per registrant and a simple random sample of registrants was drawn under seed 20261018: 30 filings in each of 2015, 2016 and 2017, where filings contain few AI sentences, and 25 in each year from 2018 to 2026, 315 filings from 281 distinct registrants, 29 of which were drawn in more than one year. The draw was not stratified by sector, so that the sample's sector mix tracks the frame's. That mix is itself part of the story: technology registrants were 42 percent of the frame in 2015 to 2019 and 16 percent in 2024 to 2026, as AI language spread from the companies that sell it to everyone else.

The draw is far from proportional across years. It takes 30 of the 36 registrants in the 2015 frame and 25 of the 3,710 in the 2026 frame, so a plain average over the sampled filings in an era would let 2015 to 2017 carry nearly two thirds of the weight in the first era when they are under a quarter of its frame. Every era and pooled estimate in this paper therefore carries a design weight, each year's registrant count in the frame divided by the number drawn in that year, and the bootstrap resamples filings within year. This was not in the original preregistration. The first draft of the paper used unweighted pooled means, an independent check of that draft flagged the problem, and the correction is recorded as Amendment 6, with the unweighted estimates published beside the weighted ones in `results/analysis_unweighted.json`. Yearly estimates are unaffected. The weighted estimand is the population of AI-mentioning filers, two thirds of which filed in the last three years, and "overall" figures below should be read with that in mind.

3.3 Extraction and the term audit

Each main document was downloaded, stripped of markup and split by the companion's deterministic sentence splitter. A sentence entered the corpus if it matched the AI term list, was between 60

and 1,200 characters, and was less than a quarter digits. The term list differs from the companion's in exactly the two ways the preregistration specified, both responses to false positives the companion documented: the pattern for the abbreviation ML was dropped because it matched millilitres, and the standalone abbreviation AI was matched case-sensitively. All 315 filings downloaded without error and yielded 2,590 sentences.

The letters AI inside a registrant's own name are the largest remaining false positive, and four sampled registrants carry them, one of which, C3.ai in 2023, contributed 448 extracted sentences. Two mechanical screens found 357 candidates: 353 sentences in which no AI term survives once the registrant's own name is removed, which is the same redaction the raters see, and four in which the abbreviation is followed by a corporate suffix or sits in a list of entity names. A blinded read of all 357 by a separate model instance confirmed 348 as containing no reference to AI other than through a name and kept nine that also mentioned machine learning models or similar. The 348 are removed from every denominator, leaving 2,242 corpus sentences in 313 filings, a median of 3 per filing and a maximum of 154, from the C3.ai filing, which is 6.9 percent of the corpus. Because one filing can carry that much weight, every sentence-level rate is reported twice: weighting every sentence equally, which is what the preregistration implied, and weighting every filing equally, which Amendment 3 made the primary presentation for exactly this reason. The two agree in direction everywhere and the filing-weighted numbers are the ones quoted in the text. One disclosure belongs here: Amendment 3 was first committed with the analysis and the paper, after the ratings, so the choice of the filing-weighted presentation was made with the results in view. The sentence-weighted figures, which are the ones the original text implied, are reported beside the filing-weighted ones throughout, and every prediction is reported on both.

The blinded read also surfaced a false positive the screens cannot catch: three sentences in two filings, a 2021 and a 2026 pharmaceutical registrant, use "an AI" to mean an aromatase inhibitor, a breast-cancer drug. All three were rated as other by both passes and stay in the corpus, which is the correct treatment under the preregistered rules and a reminder that a case-sensitive two-letter pattern is still a two-letter pattern.

4. Method

4.1 The rubric

Part A assigns each sentence exactly one of the companion's five classes, with the companion's definitions verbatim: `capability` if the sentence asserts that the registrant's own product, service or operation uses AI and attributes a capability, benefit, efficiency or performance level to it, `risk` for risk-factor language, `market` for AI in the industry, the market or at competitors, `governance` for policy, board oversight, internal controls or responsible-use programmes, and `other` for definitions, cross-references, boilerplate and anything else, including a sentence that says the registrant uses AI without saying what the AI achieves.

Part B is new. `own_use` is true when the sentence states that the registrant itself currently uses, deploys, offers, licenses, develops, trains or is implementing AI in its own products, services, operations or research, whether or not a benefit is attributed, and false for hypothetical or conditional use, for statements about other companies or the industry, for pure definitions, and for risk language that does not assert actual use. A risk sentence that asserts use in passing, "our use of AI in underwriting exposes us to model risk", is true. This is the adoption-relevant judgement: the companion found that the capability calls its reviewer overturned were sentences saying a company

uses AI without saying what it achieves, which the rubric sends to `other`, and those are exactly the sentences an adoption measure should count.

4.2 Blinding and passes

Raters saw the sentence text and nothing else. The registrant's name, with any punctuation or spacing between its tokens, and its ticker were replaced, except that a ticker which is itself an AI term (C3.ai trades as AI) was left alone so as not to erase the term being rated. Sentences were shuffled across filings and years under a fixed seed. Each sentence was assigned to two of six rater identities by cycling the fifteen rater pairs through the shuffled order. Each rater identity was a fresh, independent instance of the same commercially available large language model, with no shared context, dispatched in batches of fifty (the preregistration said about forty) with the literal prompt that is committed in `docs/RATER_PROMPT.md`, which closes the gap the companion reported. Thirty known-answer controls, sentences from the companion's calibration set whose class a blinded reviewer had fixed in September 2026 and whose automated passes had agreed, were inserted unmarked.

Every sentence on which the two passes disagreed on class or on own use, 155 in all, was rated a third time by a larger model from the same family, blind to the prior verdicts and to the fact of disagreement, mixed with 155 agreed sentences drawn at random so that selection could not reveal which were disputed. Composition is reported on two bases: agreed only, with the disputed set shown as a bound, which is the companion's convention, and majority of three.

4.3 Calibration

A seeded sample of 120 sentences stratified over the five majority classes and three eras, with ten duplicated under second identifiers, was re-read blind by the orchestrating model, which recorded a class and an own-use judgement for all 130 displays before the key was opened. The survival rate of each class and each own-use value was measured, and every composition rate was corrected by the companion's forward-transfer method, with the correction's uncertainty obtained by resampling the calibration units jointly with the filings. Corrected and uncorrected rates are both reported.

4.4 The phrase-reuse measure

For every corpus sentence, a core phrase was formed by lower-casing the sentence, tokenising it the way the search index does, and taking the twelve consecutive tokens starting at the first AI term, shifted left if the sentence ended first and moved right by up to five tokens to avoid digits and apostrophes. The phrase was submitted to EDGAR full-text search as an exact phrase over all 10-K filings since 2001, and the number of other registrants whose filings contain it, `reuse_ciks`, was recorded, with pagination past the search engine's thirty-bucket entity aggregation whenever a phrase reached it. The preregistered boilerplate flag is five or more other registrants. A window of twelve was fixed by a pilot on twenty sentences from the companion's published corpus before any corpus sentence was queried, and a sensitivity run at eight words is reported alongside.

4.5 Statistics

Proportions carry Wilson score intervals. All sentence-level and filing-level uncertainty comes from a percentile bootstrap that resamples filings within year, 10,000 replicates under a fixed seed, vectorised over per-filing count vectors, with every era and pooled statistic weighted by the design

weights of Section 3.2. Era contrasts resample the two eras independently. The corrected adoption share for a year is the raw mention share times the sampled proportion of AI-mentioning filings with at least one own-use (or capability) sentence, and the overstatement factor is the reciprocal of that proportion. Trend is summarised by Spearman's rank correlation between year and the yearly estimate and by sentence-level logistic regressions on calendar year with standard errors clustered by filing, in which every sentence is one observation and the heaviest filers therefore count most. Agreement between passes is reported as Krippendorff's alpha for nominal data (Krippendorff 2019). `src/stats.py` carries self-checks, including two published Wilson values and a cross-check of the alpha implementation against the reference package, which `requirements.txt` now lists so that the cross-check runs on a clean install.

4.6 Who the raters are

The raters, the third pass and the calibration reviewer are language models, not people: six rater identities, each a separate instance of a mid-sized commercial model, two per sentence, for the blind passes, one further instance of that model for the blinded read of the term-audit candidates, a larger model from the same family for the third pass, and the largest model in that family, which orchestrated the study, for the calibration review. The model identities and versions are recorded in a private model log and are available from the author. Nothing in the paper should be read as human inter-rater agreement. What is measured is whether independent protocol-driven passes reach the same classification, how they perform on sentences with a previously fixed answer, and how far they survive review by a more careful pass. Every sentence and every judgement is published.

5. Results

5.1 The passes agree, pass the controls, and leak a little

Across the 2,242 corpus sentences the two blind passes assigned the same class 2,121 times, an observed agreement of 94.6 percent with a Krippendorff alpha of 0.924, against 93.1 percent and 0.879 in the companion. On own use they agreed 97.7 percent of the time with an alpha of 0.952. Of the 121 class disagreements, 73 are capability against other, the boundary between using AI and saying what it achieves, and 21 are market against other. All 60 judgements on the 30 known-answer controls were correct. Treating the 30 controls as the independent units, which they are, since each was judged twice, the Wilson lower limit on accuracy is 88.6 percent, so the error rate on sentences with a fixed answer is below 11.4 percent, and the controls are an easy set, since they were chosen as sentences on which the companion's own passes had already agreed. On the 155 agreed sentences mixed into the third pass, the third-pass model agreed with the two-pass consensus 147 times on class and 152 times on own use, and it resolved 150 of the 155 disputed sentences to a majority, leaving five with three different verdicts.

Blinding leaked in two measurable ways. A sentence that says "generative AI" or "large language model" reveals that it was written after 2022, and 6.7 percent of sentences carry such a cue, and agreement on them was 93.4 percent against 94.7 percent on the rest. A distinctive token of the registrant's name survived redaction in 3.7 percent of sentences, with agreement of 91.5 percent against 94.7. Neither leak helped the raters agree.

5.2 The composition of AI language has inverted

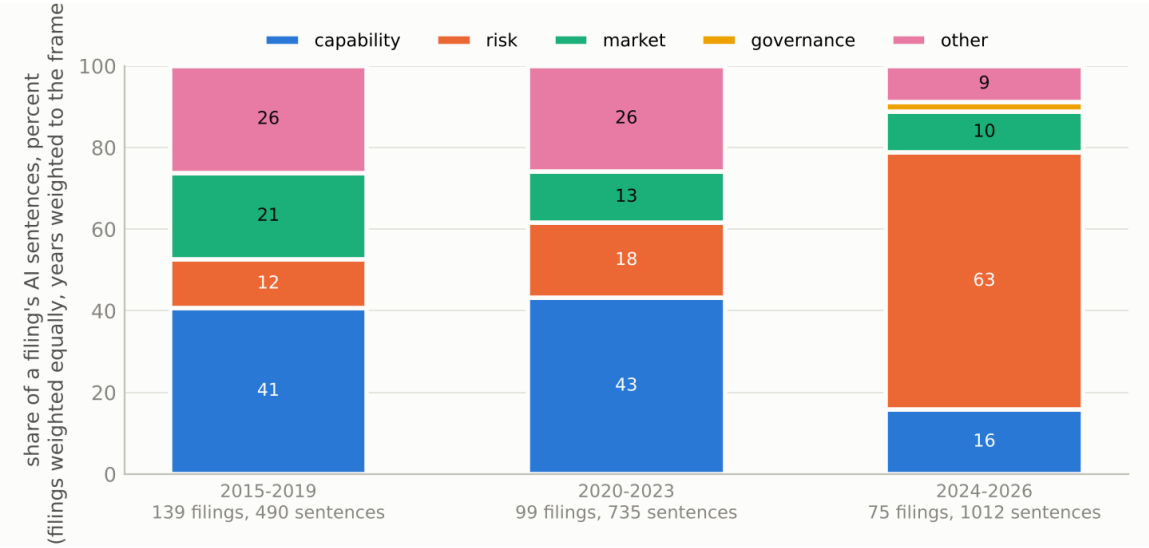


Figure 1: What a filing's AI sentences are about, by era. Majority-of-three labels, filings weighted equally within year and years weighted to the frame. Bars are point estimates and the intervals are in the text.

Figure 1 and Table 2 give the composition by era, weighting filings equally within year and years to the frame. In 2015 to 2019 an AI-mentioning filing devoted 40.6 percent of its AI sentences to claims about its own AI's capability, 26.2 percent to other, 21.2 percent to the market and 12.0 percent to risk. In 2024 to 2026 it devotes 63.0 percent to risk, 15.7 percent to capability, 9.9 percent to the market and 8.9 percent to other. Governance, absent before 2024, reaches 2.4 percent. The risk share rose by 51.1 percentage points with a bootstrap interval from 40.5 to 60.8, the capability share fell by 24.9 points (interval 14.1 to 35.6), and the own-use share fell from 51.5 to 31.2 percent, a drop of 20.3 points (8.3 to 31.9). Spearman's correlation between year and the yearly risk share is 0.937, and in a sentence-level logistic regression with filing-clustered errors the odds that an AI sentence is risk language rise by a factor of 1.52 per calendar year (interval 1.37 to 1.69) while the odds that it is a capability claim fall by a factor of 0.88 (0.84 to 0.94) and the odds that it states own use fall by 0.92 (0.86 to 0.97).

	2015 to 2019	2020 to 2023	2024 to 2026
filings, sentences	139, 490	99, 735	75, 1,012
capability	40.6 (31.3, 50.2)	43.1 (35.5, 50.9)	15.7 (10.8, 21.1)
risk	12.0 (5.7, 19.6)	18.4 (12.0, 25.6)	63.0 (55.4, 70.4)
market	21.2 (13.6, 29.5)	12.5 (8.0, 17.4)	9.9 (5.1, 15.5)
governance	0.0	0.0	2.4 (0.4, 5.6)
other	26.2 (18.8, 34.2)	25.9 (19.3, 32.9)	8.9 (6.4, 11.6)
own use	51.5 (41.7, 61.3)	54.4 (46.0, 62.7)	31.2 (24.5, 38.2)
mean sentences per filing	3.9	8.0	13.7
median sentences per filing	2	3	6

Table 2. Share of a filing's AI sentences in each class and the share stating the registrant's own use, percent, filings weighted equally within year and years weighted to the frame, majority-of-three labels, with 95 percent bootstrap intervals resampling filings within year. The counts are filings with at least one resolved sentence and the sentences they hold, which drop the five sentences on which three passes gave three different verdicts. The sentence-per-filing rows are the weighted mean and the unweighted median, and the 2020 to 2023 mean falls to 5.9 without the C3.ai filing.

Weighting every sentence equally instead, which lets the heaviest filers dominate, gives the same ordering with smaller magnitudes: the risk share rises from 8.8 to 47.3 percent (a change of 38.5 points, interval 29.3 to 48.4) and the own-use share falls from 59.7 to 49.9 percent (9.8 points, interval 3.1 up to 23.6 down, so on this basis the own-use decline is not established). On the agreed-only basis the filing-weighted era shares are within four points of the majority basis everywhere.

The inversion has two components, and the data separate them. One is who mentions AI. Technology registrants were 42 percent of the frame in the first era and 16 percent in the last, and their filings are more likely to describe a product: pooling years with the design weights, the filing-weighted capability share is 33.5 percent at technology registrants against 17.8 percent in finance and real estate, and the risk share is 31.8 percent against 43.2. The other is how much each filer says. An AI-mentioning filing carried 3.9 AI sentences on average in 2015 to 2019 and 13.7 in 2024 to 2026, with medians of 2 and 6, and nearly all of the added volume is risk language. The 2015 corpus contains sentences like iCAD's "SecondLook detects and identifies suspicious masses and micro-calcifications utilizing image processing, pattern recognition and artificial intelligence techniques" and CorVel's "CorVel's artificial intelligence engine includes over sixty million individual rules, which creates a comprehensive review process that is more efficient than traditional manual bill review processes." The 2026 corpus contains Olema Pharmaceuticals' "If we are unable to use generative AI, it could make our business less efficient and result in competitive disadvantages", a sentence whose core phrase appears in the 10-Ks of 87 other registrants.

5.3 The filers have not changed much

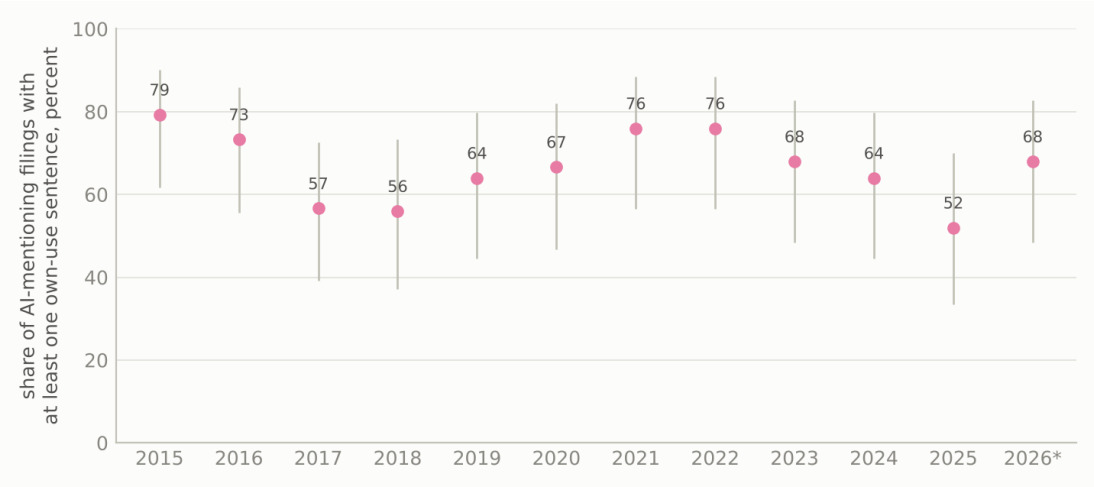


Figure 2: Share of AI-mentioning filings that contain at least one sentence stating the registrant's own use of AI, by year, with Wilson intervals. Majority-of-three labels.

The filing-level question is whether a filing that mentions AI says, anywhere, that it uses AI. Across the 313 filings with at least one corpus sentence, weighted to the frame, 64.2 percent do (interval 56.3 to 72.1) and 48.4 percent make at least one capability claim (the unweighted sample fractions are 66.8 and 57.8 percent). By era the own-use fraction is 61.6, 71.9 and 61.5 percent (Figure 2), the late-minus-early difference is 0.1 points with an interval from 15.4 points down to 15.2 points up, and Spearman's correlation between year and the yearly fraction is negative 0.20 with p = 0.53. The yearly fractions sit between 52 and 79 percent on 24 to 30 filings each and their Wilson intervals all overlap. The capability fraction does fall, from 54.2 to 40.6 percent, but the interval on the difference runs from 29.0 points down to 2.6 points up, so even the filing-level trace of the sentence-level shift from describing products to describing risk is not established at this draw.

So the two measurement failures diverge. A filing that mentions AI is about as likely to state its own use of AI in 2026 as it was in 2016, and that likelihood is about three in five. What has changed is everything around that statement.

5.4 The corrected adoption trend

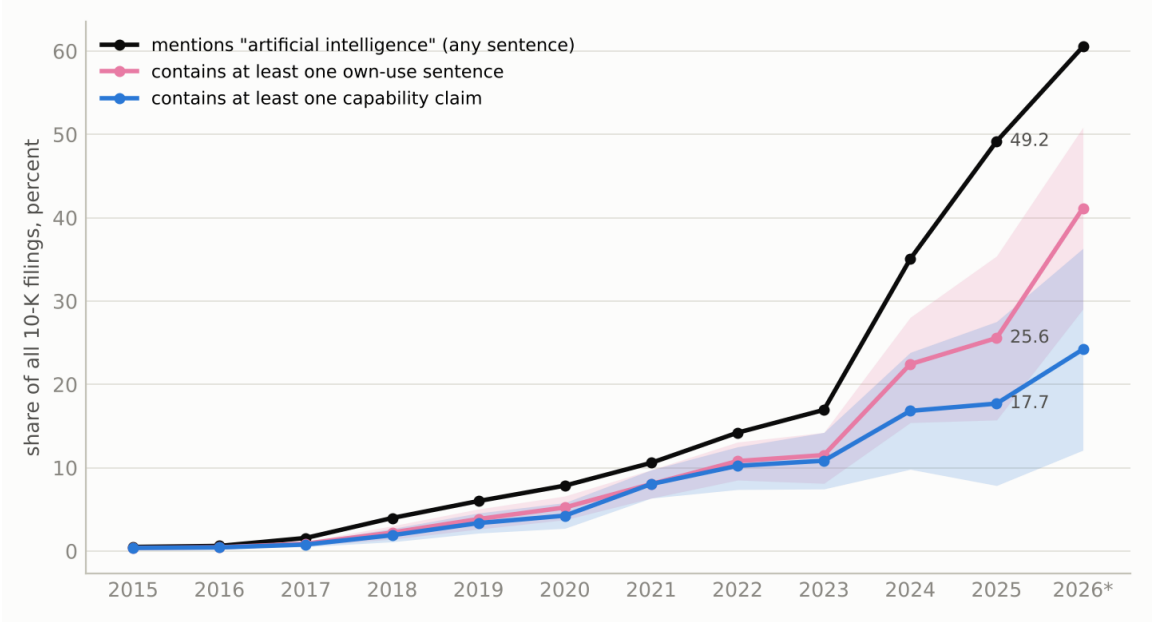


Figure 3: Share of all 10-K filings that mention "artificial intelligence", that contain at least one own-use sentence, and that contain at least one capability claim, by year. Bands are 95 percent bootstrap intervals on the sampled fraction. 2026 runs through 18 October.

Figure 3 multiplies the raw series by the sampled fractions. In 2025, 49.2 percent of 10-K filings mentioned AI, an estimated 25.6 percent (interval 15.7 to 35.4) contained an own-use statement, and 17.7 percent (7.9 to 27.5) contained a capability claim. The 2025 figure uses the 2025 draw's own fraction, 13 of 25 filings, which is the lowest of the twelve years, and the yearly fractions move around enough on 25 filings that the era figures are the better summary. Pooling the three eras, the raw share was 2.44, 12.5 and 47.9 percent and the own-use share 1.5, 9.0 and 29.5 percent. The overstatement factor, raw share over own-use share, is 1.62 (interval 1.38 to 1.97) in 2015 to 2019, 1.39 (1.24 to 1.61) in 2020 to 2023 and 1.63 (1.38 to 1.98) in 2024 to 2026. The last era and the first are equal to the second decimal, the interval on their difference runs from 0.43

down to 0.43 up and 51 percent of bootstrap replicates are positive, so there is no evidence that the overstatement has grown. The practical reading is that the filing count overstates own-use adoption by a factor between 1.4 and 1.6 in every era, and overstates capability-claiming adoption by more in the recent years: the capability factor is 2.5 in 2024 to 2026 against 1.8 in 2015 to 2019. These fractions are not corrected for the calibration results of Section 5.7. Since a filing needs only one own-use sentence to count and the reviewer overturned false own-use calls more often than true ones, a corrected fraction would if anything be higher.

year	raw share	own-use share	capability share	filings
2015	0.50	0.39 (0.32, 0.46)	0.38 (0.30, 0.45)	29
2018	3.97	2.22 (1.43, 3.02)	1.91 (1.11, 2.70)	25
2021	10.59	8.05 (6.35, 9.74)	8.05 (6.35, 9.74)	25
2023	16.94	11.52 (8.13, 14.23)	10.84 (7.45, 14.23)	25
2024	35.05	22.43 (15.42, 28.04)	16.82 (9.81, 23.83)	25
2025	49.17	25.57 (15.73, 35.40)	17.70 (7.87, 27.53)	25
2026	60.53	41.16 (29.05, 50.84)	24.21 (12.11, 36.32)	25

Table 3. Share of all original 10-K filings, percent, with 95 percent bootstrap intervals on the sampled fraction. All twelve years are in `results/analysis.json`.

5.5 Verbatim reuse is rare, and it is risk language

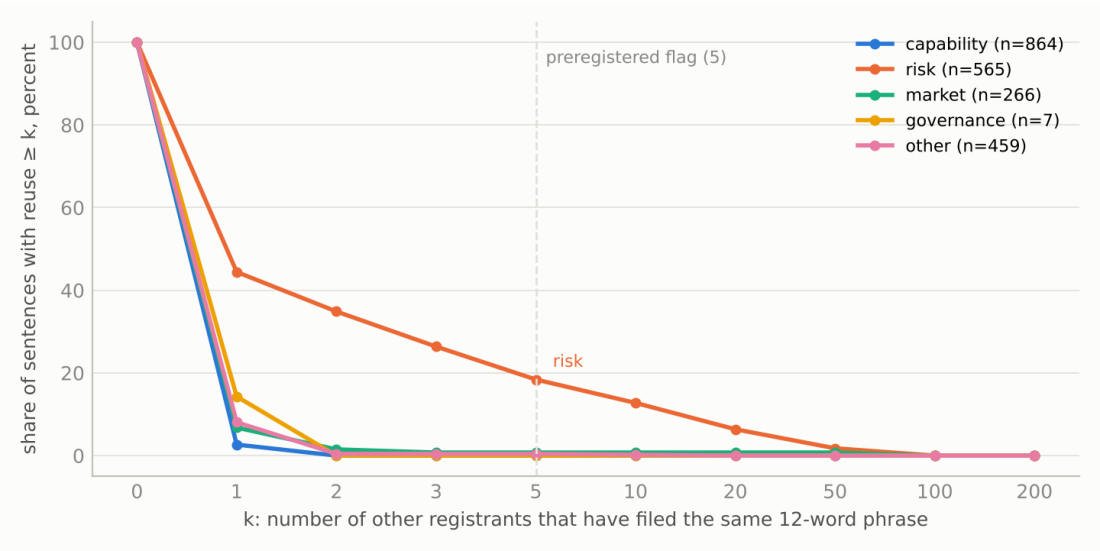


Figure 4: Share of sentences whose twelve-word core phrase appears in the 10-K filings of at least k other registrants, by majority class.

All 2,242 corpus sentences were queried without error, 96.5 percent found their own filing, and 76 returned no hit at all, which marks a normalisation failure rather than a rare phrase and leaves 2,166 sentences in the reuse analysis. For 84.8 percent of them, no other registrant has ever filed a 10-K containing the same twelve-word phrase. Five percent are shared with five or more other registrants and one percent with thirty or more, up to a maximum of 87. Boilerplate in the sense of

verbatim cross-filer copying is therefore uncommon in AI language at this window length, and the eight-word sensitivity run moves the flagged share only from 5.0 to 6.2 percent.

What reuse there is sits almost entirely in one class (Figure 4). Of 864 capability sentences, none is shared with five or more other registrants and 97.3 percent are shared with none, so the preregistered flag has a Wilson upper bound of 0.4 percent on capability. Of 565 risk sentences, 104, or 18.4 percent (interval 15.4 to 21.8), are flagged and 44.4 percent are shared with at least one other registrant, with a 90th percentile of twelve other registrants. Market and other sentences are flagged at 0.8 and 0.4 percent. As a detector of risk language the flag is almost perfectly specific and weakly sensitive: 96.3 percent of flagged sentences are risk sentences and 18.4 percent of risk sentences are flagged. As a detector of "not an own-use statement" it is weak, with an area under the curve of 0.58, because most non-own-use sentences are also unshared: at the preregistered flag, 71.3 percent of flagged sentences are not own-use statements and 8.4 percent of non-own-use sentences are flagged. The eight-word window flags 22.7 percent of risk sentences and 0.1 percent of capability sentences.

The flagged share of a filing's AI sentences is 0.0 percent in 2015 to 2019, 2.8 percent in 2020 to 2023 and 12.3 percent in 2024 to 2026 (interval 7.4 to 17.7), a rise of 12.3 points (interval 7.4 to 17.7), and weighting sentences equally the rise is 10.4 points (7.1 to 14.2). The most reused sentences are the generic AI risk factors of the last three years: the inability to use generative AI (87 other registrants), AI outputs being deficient or biased (78), competitors incorporating AI faster (74), AI ethics controversy (68), and the cost of complying with AI regulation (63). The only non-risk sentences in the top twelve are two filers' copies of the "collectively, AI" definition that opens many registrants' AI risk factors.

5.6 Sectors and size

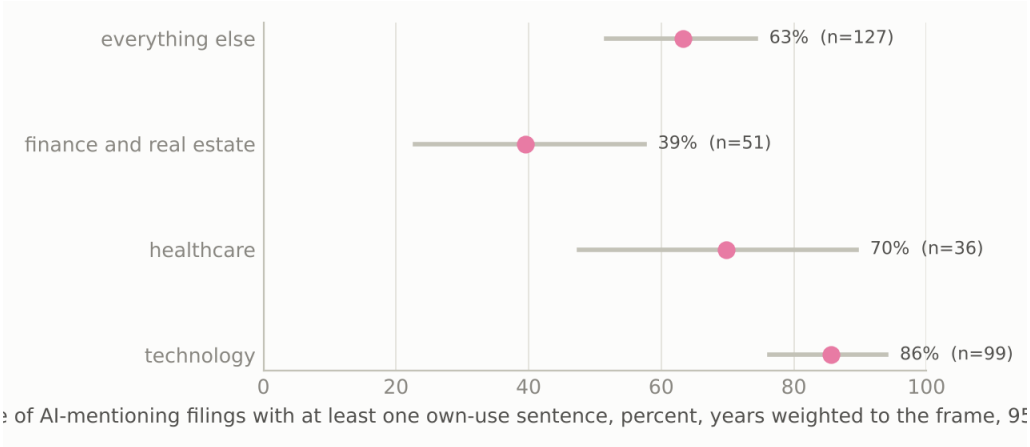


Figure 5: Share of AI-mentioning filings with at least one own-use sentence, by sector, pooled across years, with 95 percent bootstrap intervals.

Pooling all years with the design weights, 85.7 percent of technology registrants' AI-mentioning filings state their own use of AI (79 of 99 in the sample, interval 76.3 to 94.0), against 69.8 percent in healthcare (24 of 36), 39.5 percent in finance and real estate (28 of 51) and 63.2 percent in everything else (78 of 127). The unweighted sample fractions are 79.8, 66.7, 54.9 and 61.4 percent, and the finance estimate in particular rests on a few heavily weighted recent filings, which its interval of

22.9 to 57.5 reflects. The difference between technology and the other three strata pooled is 26.9 points with an interval from 13.8 to 39.4 (19.1 points, 8.9 to 28.7, unweighted), so preregistered prediction 7 holds either way. The ordering of sectors under the raw mention measure, which the preregistration also asked for, needs the sector of every 10-K filer in the denominator and was not collected. Registrant size, from the total assets each filing reported to the XBRL API, available for 308 of 315 filings, makes no detectable difference to the own-use fraction (61.7 percent above the median of about one billion dollars against 66.6 percent below, difference 4.9 points, interval 20.1 down to 10.6 up) but a large one to composition: the filing-weighted risk share is 57.7 percent at larger registrants (interval 50.9 to 64.1) and 34.5 percent at smaller ones (26.1 to 42.8), a difference of 23.1 points (12.6 to 34.0). Part of that gap is mechanical, since smaller reporting companies are not required to provide Item 1A risk factors at all, part may be counsel, and the comparison pools years without adjusting for the fact that larger registrants are a different mix of years.

5.7 Calibration

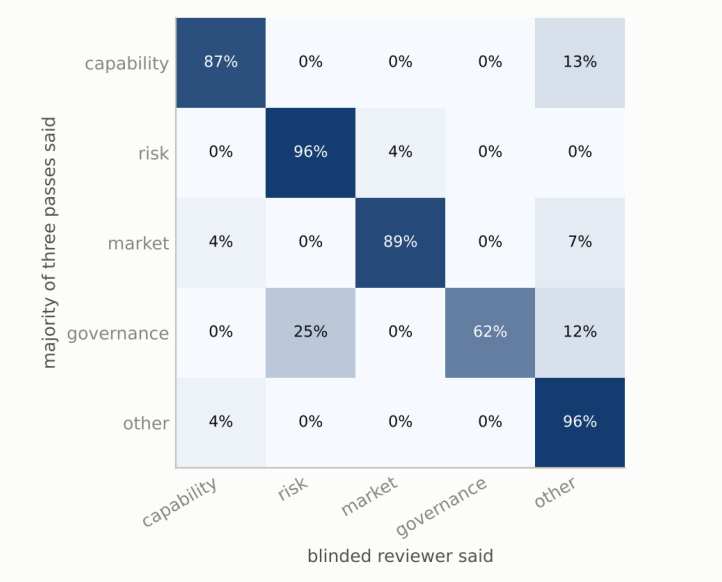


Figure 6: Where the majority verdicts went under blinded review, 120 units. Rows are what the majority of three passes said, columns what the blinded reviewer said. Diagonal cells are survival rates.

The reviewer was consistent with itself on all ten duplicate controls, on class and on own use. Of 120 majority verdicts, 108 survived review, 90.0 percent: 96.3 percent of risk calls (26 of 27), 96.3 percent of other (26 of 27), 89.3 percent of market (25 of 28), 86.7 percent of capability (26 of 30) and 62.5 percent of governance (5 of 8). Own-use calls survived at 94.4 percent when true and 89.4 percent when false. The errors have the same direction as in the companion: all four overturned capability calls went to other, and all four were product-list fragments, service descriptions or aspirations that name AI without attributing anything to it. Governance, the smallest class at 8 of 2,237 resolved sentences, is the least reliable, and three of its eight units went to risk or other. Survival was 91.2 percent in the first era, 94.9 in the second and 85.1 in the third.

Forward-transfer correction moves the filing-weighted capability share from 40.6 to 36.9 percent (interval 27.5 to 46.9) in the first era and from 15.7 to 14.3 (9.7 to 19.6) in the last, and the own-use

share from 51.5 to 53.8 (44.3 to 63.5) and from 31.2 to 36.7 (28.9 to 44.8). The risk share barely moves, from 12.0 to 11.5 (5.4 to 18.9) and from 63.0 to 61.3 (52.7 to 69.5). The era contrasts after correction, with the calibration units resampled jointly with the filings, are 49.8 points for risk (interval 39.0 to 60.1), 22.6 points for capability (13.0 to 32.5) and 17.0 points for own use (7.1 to 27.5). The composition shift of Section 5.2 is therefore not an artefact of the systematic errors the review could detect. That is a weaker statement than it sounds, for two reasons the reader should weigh: the reviewer is the model that orchestrated the study, with a stake in the result, and the correction is applied to the composition rates only, not to the filing-level fractions of Sections 5.3 and 5.4, which the preregistration said would also be corrected and which are published uncorrected.

5.8 Replication of the 2025 companion

The 25 filings drawn here for 2025 give a sentence-weighted agreed-basis risk share of 49.5 percent (interval 37.6 to 64.8) and a capability share of 28.5 percent (11.0 to 42.5). The companion's 59 filings with corpus sentences gave 65.5 and 13.5 percent on the same agreed basis before calibration and 60.5 and 12.2 after it. The companion's values lie inside both intervals here, but the capability point estimate here is about twice the companion's. Three things differ. The companion stratified by sector and this study did not. The draw here is thin relative to the 2025 frame, 25 of 3,153 registrants, as it is in 2026. And the two sets of raters sit at slightly different places on the capability-versus-other boundary, which the calibration surfaces here as a 13 percent transfer out of capability and the companion reported as 13 percent too, so a corrected figure here would move toward the companion's. Weighting filings equally, the 2025 risk share here is 67.5 percent and the capability share 11.2 percent, close to the companion's figures. The honest summary is that the two studies agree within their uncertainty and that 25 filings is a loose replication.

5.9 The preregistered predictions

All predictions are evaluated on the filing-weighted, majority-of-three basis with the design weights of Amendment 6, and the unweighted outcomes are stated where they differ. Prediction 1, that the risk share would be higher in 2024 to 2026 than in 2015 to 2019, held by 51 points with an interval well away from zero, and holds weighting sentences equally as well. Prediction 2, that the own-use share would be lower, held by 20 points, clear of zero on the filing-weighted basis, while the sentence-weighted interval includes zero. Prediction 3, that fewer than 60 percent of AI-mentioning filings in 2024 to 2026 would contain any own-use sentence, failed: 46 of 75 did, 61.3 percent, with a Wilson interval from 50.0 to 71.5. The prediction was built on the companion's finding that 19 of 59 filings contained a capability claim, and it underestimated how often a filing states use without claiming capability. Prediction 4 was a conjunction of two criteria. The median reuse count is zero for both risk and capability sentences, so the median-ratio criterion cannot be evaluated, which the preregistration did not anticipate, and the flag-rate criterion, that risk would be flagged at least twice as often as capability, held at 18.4 percent against zero. The prediction as written therefore neither held nor failed, and it is counted as held on one of its two criteria. Prediction 5, that the flagged share would rise, held by 12.3 points filing-weighted and 10.4 sentence-weighted. Prediction 6, that the overstatement factor would be larger in the last era, is not supported: the factors are 1.63 and 1.62, a difference with an interval from 0.43 below zero to 0.43 above. Unweighted, the same comparison was 1.63 against 1.51, a point-estimate difference that the first draft of this paper reported as holding on its point estimate, and the design weights remove it. Prediction 7, that technology registrants would have a higher own-use rate, held by 27 points (19 unweighted). The tally is four held with intervals clear of zero, one held on one of two criteria, one not supported, and one failed. The

falsification condition, a risk share stable within five points and no growth in overstatement, was not met, because the risk share moved by 51 points even though the overstatement did not grow.

5.10 An external anchor

The Census Bureau's Business Trends and Outlook Survey (U.S. Census Bureau 2026) asks a national sample of businesses whether they used AI in any business function in the prior two weeks. In the cycle collected from 21 September to 4 October 2026 the national rate was 23.8 percent and the Information sector's rate was 50.2 percent, the highest of any sector. These are different populations, all employer businesses against public registrants, and a different question, use in the prior fortnight against any statement of use in an annual report, so the comparison is an anchor and not a validation. It does say that the raw 10-K mention share, 60.5 percent of filings in 2026, sits above even the survey's most AI-intensive sector, while the corrected own-use share of 41.2 percent sits between the survey's national rate and its Information-sector rate. The sector-by-sector comparison the preregistration described as exploratory was not carried out, for the same reason as the sector ordering in Section 5.6.

6. What this means

6.1 For anyone using the count

The count of 10-K filings mentioning artificial intelligence can be used as an adoption measure if it is scaled, and the scaling has not drifted: divide by a factor between 1.4 and 1.6 to get the share of filers that state their own use of AI, with era intervals that together span 1.24 to 1.98. The count of AI sentences, or of AI words, cannot be used that way, because its composition inverted between 2019 and 2024. In a filing from 2024 to 2026, weighting filings equally, 63 percent of the AI sentences are risk language and 16 percent are capability claims, a ratio of four to one, and weighting sentences equally, where the heaviest filers dominate, the shares are 47 and 28 percent. The own-use share is higher than the capability share on either basis, 31 and 50 percent, because it includes risk sentences that mention the filer's use of AI in passing. Any study that uses the volume of AI language as a firm-level intensity measure is, after 2023, measuring the length of the AI risk factor to a large degree: about half of the sentence volume and nearly two thirds of the typical filing's AI sentences.

6.2 For what boilerplate means

The word boilerplate is used for two different things, and this study separates them. In the sense of verbatim text shared across filers, the measure that Lang and Stice-Lawrence (2015) made standard, AI language is mostly not boilerplate: 85 percent of twelve-word AI phrases are unique to their filer, and a twenty-sentence pilot on the companion study's corpus showed the same pattern. In the sense of defensive, generic, non-specific language, the sense Hope, Hu and Lu (2016) show the market discounts, AI language has become mostly boilerplate: 63 percent of a filing's AI sentences are now risk factors, and the risk factors that are shared verbatim are the generic ones about competitors, regulators and ethics. The phrase-reuse detector is therefore useful for what it is, a cheap and nearly perfectly specific flag for the most generic risk language, and not for what one might want it to be, a substitute for reading. A model reading every sentence found about five times as much risk language as the detector flagged.

6.3 For the drafting equilibrium

Why has the language diluted while the filers have not? The simplest account is the one the risk-factor literature has given for other topics since Campbell et al. (2014): once a topic becomes salient to litigation and to the Commission, counsel adds a risk factor about it to every filing where it could conceivably apply, and the risk factor is long. The Commission's AI-washing actions (U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission 2024, 2025) made AI exactly that kind of topic, but they cannot be what started the jump. The first of them was announced on 18 March 2024, and 19 of the 25 sampled 2024 filings were made before that date with a filing-weighted risk share already at 65.2 percent, against 43.2 percent for the six made after it (an exploratory split, difference 22 points with an interval from 49 down to 5 up). The risk factors arrived with the first annual reports written after ChatGPT, and the enforcement actions, if they mattered, kept them there. The result is that the registrants who adopted AI early and wrote about their products now write about their products and about risk, and the registrants who have not adopted it write about risk alone, and both show up in the count. Whether the added risk language carries information, as Campbell et al. found for risk factors generally, or is discounted as generic, as Hope, Hu and Lu found for non-specific ones, is a question this design cannot answer and the next study should.

7. Limitations

Twenty-five filings per year. The yearly filing-level fractions have Wilson intervals between 28 and 37 points wide, which is why the trend conclusions rest on the pooled eras and on the sentence-level regressions, and why Table 3's intervals are as wide as they are. A study whose primary question was a single year's adoption rate would need several times the draw.

The weighting was decided late. Both weighting decisions that shape the headline magnitudes, filings over sentences (Amendment 3) and design weights over a pooled sample (Amendment 6), were committed after the ratings and, in the second case, after the first draft of the paper. Every estimate is published on every basis, the directions agree on all of them, and the one prediction whose outcome depends on the choice (Prediction 6) is reported as not supported.

One registrant is one fourteenth of the corpus. The term audit removed most of C3.ai's name mentions, but its 2023 filing still carries 154 corpus sentences, 6.9 percent of the total. The filing-weighted presentation exists for this reason, and the sentence-weighted numbers are published beside it.

The frame is a phrase. A filing that discusses machine learning at length without writing "artificial intelligence" is not in the frame, in any year. Yearly EDGAR hit counts for "machine learning", enumerated for this study, are published in the preregistration for comparison.

The raters are models, and the reviewer is the orchestrator. No human read these sentences. The passes were checked against thirty known answers, against each other, against a third pass, and against a blinded review by a different model, and the blinded review is itself the model that orchestrated the study, with a stake in the result. The materials for a human replication are in `data/rating/` and `data/calibration/`.

Blinding is imperfect. Era cues reveal the period for 6.7 percent of sentences and a name token survives in 3.7 percent. Both are measured and neither raised agreement.

The third-pass model differs from the blind-pass models. Majority labels mix two blind-pass verdicts with one third-pass verdict on 155 sentences. The agreed-only basis, which uses no third-

pass verdict, gives the same era shares within four points.

The calibration cells are small, and the correction is partial. Governance has eight units and capability thirty. The corrected composition rates carry the calibration uncertainty in their intervals and the era contrasts do not change direction under correction, but the filing-level fractions and Table 3 are not corrected, although the preregistration said every rate would be.

The reuse measure is one window at one length. Twelve tokens starting at the AI term is one of many possible definitions, chosen by a pilot on twenty sentences and fixed in advance. The eight-word run shows the conclusions are not sensitive to the length, but a four-gram measure of the Lang and Stice-Lawrence kind, applied over whole filings rather than AI sentences, would be a different and worthwhile study.

2026 is partial. The 2026 frame and denominator run through 18 October. Most 10-Ks are filed in the first quarter, so the year is nearly complete, but the raw share for 2026 will move slightly by December.

8. Conclusion

In 2015 one 10-K in two hundred mentioned artificial intelligence, and the typical AI sentence in those filings described what the filer's product could do. In 2025 nearly one in two mentioned it, and the typical AI sentence described what could go wrong. The share of a filing's AI language that is risk language rose from twelve percent to sixty-three percent, the share that claims a capability fell from two fifths to one sixth, and the share that states any use by the filer fell from 52 to 31 percent. The filers themselves changed far less: about three in five AI-mentioning filers state their own use of AI in every era. A count of filings is therefore still a usable adoption measure once divided by a factor between 1.4 and 1.6, and a count of AI words or sentences is not.

The verbatim-reuse detector adds a precise and limited tool. Almost no capability claim is shared across filers, and the risk factors that are shared are the generic ones, so a phrase that five other registrants have also filed is a risk factor with 96 percent precision. It catches less than a fifth of the risk language, which is the measure of how much of the dilution is template rather than copy.

Of seven preregistered predictions, four held with intervals clear of zero, one held on one of its two criteria, one was not supported, and one failed at the boundary the author set. The one that failed is the useful one: a filing that mentions AI is more likely to state its own use of AI than the companion study's capability rate suggested, because some filers say they use AI without saying what it does for them. Capability claims still outnumber those bare statements, 895 sentences against 403 and 181 filings against 28, but the 28 filings whose only own-use language is "we use AI", with nothing after it, are the difference between the companion's capability rate and the own-use rate measured here.

Data and code

Everything is at `https://github.com/ishaanshah101/ai-disclosure-trend-audit`. `src/frame.py` enumerates the frame, `src/denominators.py` counts the 10-Ks, `src/sample_filings.py` draws the sample, `src/fetch_and_extract.py` downloads and extracts, `src/term_audit.py` screens, `src/build_rating_sets.py` blinds and assigns, `src/validate_ratings.py` checks every judgement against the schema, `src/agreement.py` measures agreement, controls and leakage, `src/third_pass.py` builds and merges the third pass, `src/build_calibration.py` builds

and scores the calibration, `src/phrase_reuse.py` measures reuse, `src/xbrl_size.py` fetches registrant size, `src/analyze.py` produces every number here, `src/figures.py` draws the figures, `src/build_browser.py` builds a page on which every sentence and verdict can be read, and `src/verify_paper.py` recomputes the headline era estimates, the filing-level fractions and the corpus counts directly from the committed labels, checks every other number quoted in this paper against `results/analysis.json`, and exits non-zero on any mismatch. `src/analyze.py --unweighted` produces the pooled-sample comparison file. The preregistration, its six amendments and its record of deviations are in `docs/PREREGISTRATION.md`, the literal rater prompt in `docs/RATER_PROMPT.md`, the companion study's figures used for comparison in `data/companion_values.json`, and the verified reference list in `docs/REFERENCES_VERIFIED.md`. Raw 10-K documents are not committed and are reproduced by `src/fetch_and_extract.py` from the committed accession numbers.

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